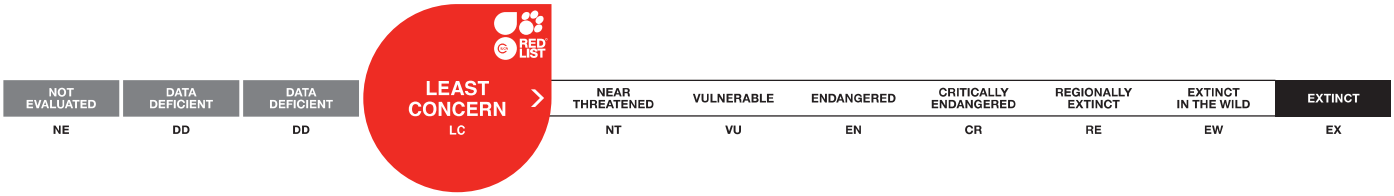
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Language: English

Castor fiber, Eurasian Beaver

Assessment by: Gazzard, A.



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Taxonomy

Kingdom	Phylum	Class	Order	Family
Animalia	Chordata	Mammalia	Rodentia	Castoridae

Scientific Name: *Castor fiber* Linnaeus, 1758

Common Name(s):

- English: Eurasian Beaver, European Beaver
- French: Castor d'Eurasie
- Spanish; Castilian: Castor Europeo
- German: Eurasischer Biber
- Italian: Castoro europeo

Taxonomic Source(s):

ASM. 2021. Mammal Diversity Database (Version 1.9). Zenodo. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.4139722. American Society of Mammalogists (ASM). Available at: www.mammaldiversity.org. (Accessed: 23 May 2022).

Assessment Information

Red List Category & Criteria: Least Concern ver 3.1

Year Published: 2024

Date Assessed: February 07 2023

Justification:

European regional assessment: Least Concern (LC)
EU 27 regional assessment: Least Concern (LC)

This species has shown good recovery across much of its range as a result of numerous conservation and reintroduction programmes. In Europe, numbers are growing and population expansion is expected to continue in the future. As such, this species is assessed as Least Concern for both Europe and the EU 27 Member States.

Regional Assessments:

Global

Mediterranean

Previously Published Red List Assessments

2007 – Least Concern (LC)

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Geographic Range

Range Description:

The Eurasian Beaver (*Castor fiber*) was once widespread in Europe. However, by the beginning of the 20th century, overhunting had drastically reduced both the numbers and range of this species. In Europe, only a few isolated sites remained: parts of the Rhône (France) and Elbe (Germany), southern Norway, the Neman River, the Dnieper Basin (Belarus) and the Voronezh Basin (Russia). A series of management measures and reintroductions since the 20th century have enabled the Eurasian Beaver to return to much of its former range, and there are now several rapidly expanding subpopulations extending from Spain and France across central and eastern Europe to European Russia. Its distribution is thus mapped on this assessment as native (capturing all areas of remnant populations, populations reintroduced from the 19th century onwards, and that have spread naturally within the native range from both remnant and reintroduced populations). Today, the majority of the European population is found in central and eastern Europe (Wróbel 2020), with subpopulations in western Europe relatively scattered, but growing. The species has become re-established in all countries of its former European range except for Portugal, Italy, and the southern Balkans (Halley *et al*. 2021), though future range expansions are likely. It is generally a lowland species but occurs up to 1,387 m in France (Poitevin and Quéré 2021)

Outside of the assessment area, the Eurasian Beaver also occurs in Asian Russia, Kazakhstan, Mongolia and China.

Country Occurrence:

Native, Extant (resident): Belarus; France (France (mainland)); Germany; Italy (Italy (mainland)); Luxembourg; Norway; Russian Federation (European Russia); Ukraine

Native, Extinct: Portugal; Türkiye (Türkiye-in-Europe)

Extant & Reintroduced (resident): Austria; Belgium; Croatia; Czechia; Denmark; Estonia; Finland; Hungary; Latvia; Liechtenstein; Lithuania; Netherlands; Poland; Romania; Serbia; Slovakia; Slovenia; Spain; Sweden; Switzerland; Ukraine; United Kingdom (Great Britain)

Extant & Origin Uncertain (resident): Bulgaria

Extant & Origin Uncertain: Bosnia and Herzegovina

Presence Uncertain & Origin Uncertain: Moldova

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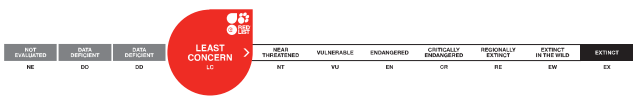
Distribution Map



Tiles (C) Esri -- Esri, DeLorme, NAVTEQ, TomTom, Intermap, iPC, USGS, FAO, NPS, NRCAN, GeoBase, Kadaster NL, Ordnance Survey, Esri Japan, METI, Esri China (Hong Kong), and the GIS User Community

Compiled by: IUCN SSC Small Mammal Specialist Group 2023

EXTANT (RESIDENT)





The boundaries and names shown and the designations used on this map do not imply any official endorsement, acceptance or opinion by IUCN.

Population

By the beginning of the 20th century, the global population had been reduced to eight subpopulations, totalling approximately 1,200 individuals (Halley and Rosell 2002). Protection, reintroductions and natural spread since the early 1900s have now resulted in considerable population growth across much of the Eurasian Beaver's historic range. The minimum population estimate of the Eurasian Beaver in 2002 stood at 593,000 individuals (Halley and Rosell 2002), and continued population growth has resulted in the more recent minimum estimate reaching 1,479,863 individuals in Europe (Halley *et al*. 2021). A review of country-specific population numbers can be found in Halley *et al*. (2021).

Current Population Trend: Increasing

Habitat and Ecology

(see Appendix for additional information)

The Eurasian Beaver is one of the largest rodents (15-20 kg, rarely up to 40 kg) and is adapted for a semi-aquatic lifestyle, using a variety of freshwater systems, including rivers, streams, irrigation ditches, lakes, and swamps (Wilson *et al*. 2016). It generally prefers freshwater habitats surrounded by woodland or scrub, but may occur in agricultural land or even suburban and urban areas (Tattersall 1999, Halley and Rosell 2002). Patterns of recolonisation demonstrate a clear preference for still or slow, laminar water flow if it is available (Nowak 1999, Halley and Rosell 2002, Halley pers. comm. 2006). It is often associated with wetlands containing *Salicaceae* species (e.g. willows, aspens, poplars) (Piton *et al*. 2020).

The Eurasian Beaver lives in family groups of an adult pair, kits and subadults, and can establish territories spanning 1.8-4 km of water bank (Gaywood 2017). It feeds on aquatic and terrestrial herbaceous vegetation and broadleaved woody vegetation. It can construct dams to retain water, create feeding areas (this may be particularly important when terrestrial vegetation is difficult to access), provide safe refuge, facilitate travel and aid the transport of woody material (Gaywood 2017, Mohr Mortensen *et al*. 2021). They rest in burrows and/or lodges.

Systems: Terrestrial, Freshwater (=Inland waters)

Use and Trade

(see Appendix for additional information)

Where populations have recovered well, the Eurasian Beaver is a seasonal game species (Yanuta *et al*. 2022).

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Threats

(see Appendix for additional information)

The Eurasian Beaver's historic decline was caused by over-hunting for fur, meat and castoreum (a secretion from the scent glands), combined with the loss of wetland habitats. Beaver subpopulations were severely reduced in most countries by medieval times, but the species clung on in marshes and other inaccessible places until the advent of efficient steel traps and accurate firearms in the 17th century; then, through to the 19th century, there was a rash of final extinctions for these reasons, combined with the drainage of many of the large marshland areas (all of the European refugia where the species survived, except in Norway, are extensive marshlands).

Today, Eurasian Beaver subpopulations in Europe are expanding rapidly, and there are no major threats of a magnitude likely to cause a decline at the regional level. Competitive exclusion of the native Eurasian Beaver by its American cousin, the North American Beaver (*C. canadensis*) may be a risk in parts of Finland and northwest Russia, but the mechanisms behind their competition are unclear (Halley *et al*. 2021) since in other areas, the North American Beaver is 'losing ground' to the Eurasian Beaver (Danilov and Fyodorov 2016). In any case, European Union member states are required to control or contain North American beavers as an invasive species. Thus, competitive exclusion is not considered to be a major threat regionally.

Roadkill is an important source of mortality for some subpopulations (Tattersall 1999). Rapidly expanding beaver subpopulations may also come into conflict with humans in some areas, as they can cause damage to forestry and crops, though such damages tend to be less severe than those caused by other species such as deer and voles (Halley and Rosell 2002).

Conservation Actions

(see Appendix for additional information)

A number of conservation measures have contributed to the species' recovery in Europe, including reintroductions and translocations, hunting restrictions, and habitat protection. It is listed under the Bern Convention (Appendix III) and the EU Habitats and Species Directive (Annex V for the Swedish and Finnish populations, Annex II and IV for all others). Early provision of interpretation and public viewing opportunities as well as education programmes are recommended, as this provides a benefit to the local economy through wildlife tourism, and helps foster positive attitudes toward beavers (Halley and Rosell 2002). Further research into the population trends could be beneficial.

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Authority/Authorities: IUCN SSC Small Mammal Specialist Group

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Citation

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Appendix

For more information on IUCN Classification Schemes referenced in this appendix, please visit: http://www.iucnredlist.org/technical-documents/classification-schemes

Habitats

Habitat	Season	Suitability	Major Importance?
1. Forest -> 1.1. Forest - Boreal	Resident	Suitable	Yes
1. Forest -> 1.4. Forest - Temperate	Resident	Suitable	Yes
3. Shrubland -> 3.3. Shrubland - Boreal	Resident	Marginal	-
3. Shrubland -> 3.4. Shrubland - Temperate	Resident	Marginal	-
5. Wetlands (inland) -> 5.1. Wetlands (inland) - Permanent Rivers/Streams/Creeks (includes waterfalls)	Resident	Suitable	Yes
5. Wetlands (inland) -> 5.5. Wetlands (inland) - Permanent Freshwater Lakes (over 8ha)	Resident	Suitable	Yes
5. Wetlands (inland) -> 5.6. Wetlands (inland) - Seasonal/Intermittent Freshwater Lakes (over 8ha)	Resident	Suitable	Yes
5. Wetlands (inland) -> 5.7. Wetlands (inland) - Permanent Freshwater Marshes/Pools (under 8ha)	Resident	Suitable	Yes
14. Artificial/Terrestrial -> 14.2. Artificial/Terrestrial - Pastureland	Resident	Marginal	-
14. Artificial/Terrestrial -> 14.5. Artificial/Terrestrial - Urban Areas	Resident	Marginal	-

Use and Trade

End Use	Local	National	International
15. Sport hunting/specimen collecting	No	No	No

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Threats

Threat	Timing	Scope	Severity
5. Biological resource use -> 5.1. Hunting & trapping terrestrial animals -> 5.1.1. Intentional use (species is the target) **Stresses:** 2. Species Stresses -> 2.1. Species mortality	Ongoing	Unknown	Unknown
5. Biological resource use -> 5.3. Logging & wood harvesting -> 5.3.3. Unintentional effects: (subsistence/small scale) [harvest] **Stresses:** 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.1. Ecosystem conversion	Ongoing	Unknown	Unknown
7. Natural system modifications -> 7.2. Dams & water management/use -> 7.2.11. Dams (size unknown) **Stresses:** 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.1. Ecosystem conversion	Ongoing	Unknown	Unknown
7. Natural system modifications -> 7.3. Other ecosystem modifications **Stresses:** 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.1. Ecosystem conversion 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation	Ongoing	Unknown	Unknown
8. Invasive and other problematic species, genes & diseases -> 8.1. Invasive non-native/alien species/diseases -> 8.1.2. Named species (Castor canadensis) **Stresses:** 2. Species Stresses -> 2.3. Indirect species effects -> 2.3.2. Competition	Ongoing	Minority (<50%)	Unknown
9. Pollution -> 9.2. Industrial & military effluents -> 9.2.3. Type Unknown/Unrecorded **Stresses:** 1. Ecosystem stresses -> 1.2. Ecosystem degradation	Ongoing	Unknown	Unknown

Conservation Actions in Place

Conservation Action in Place
In-place land/water protection
Occurs in at least one protected area: Yes
In-place species management
Harvest management plan: Yes
Successfully reintroduced or introduced benignly: Yes
In-place education
Subject to recent education and awareness programmes: Yes
Included in international legislation: Yes

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Conservation Actions Needed

Conservation Action Needed	Notes
1. Land/water protection -> 1.1. Site/area protection	-
2. Land/water management -> 2.1. Site/area management	-
2. Land/water management -> 2.3. Habitat & natural process restoration	-
3. Species management -> 3.1. Species management -> 3.1.1. Harvest management	-
3. Species management -> 3.3. Species re-introduction -> 3.3.1. Reintroduction	-
4. Education & awareness -> 4.1. Formal education	-
4. Education & awareness -> 4.3. Awareness & communications	-

Research Needed

Research Needed	Notes
1. Research -> 1.2. Population size, distribution & trends	-
1. Research -> 1.4. Harvest, use & livelihoods	-
3. Monitoring -> 3.1. Population trends	-

Additional Data Fields

Distribution
Estimated extent of occurrence (EOO) (km^2): 9410949
Continuing decline in extent of occurrence (EOO): No
Lower elevation limit (m): 0
Upper elevation limit (m): 1387

Population
Number of mature individuals: 1479863
Continuing decline of mature individuals: No
Extreme fluctuations: No
Population severely fragmented: No

Habitats and Ecology
Generation Length (years): 9

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